What matters of state was the ruler expected to oversee? If the *Arthashastra* is to be believed, the range was formidable. The countryside had to be settled ('by bringing in people from foreign lands or by shifting the overflow from his own country') and irrigation works built.[8] On the frontiers, fortresses for frontier chiefs had to be set up. Work in mines and factories, and trade in ports and via trade routes, had to be supported, revenue from such areas being central to state requirements. The king had to protect his subjects by the wielding of danda (coercion), 'For the Rod, used after full consideration, endows the subjects with spiritual good, material well-being and pleasures of the senses.' And the social order had to be preserved, presumably in conformity with the system of varnas and ashramas.[9] The key to the king's success was his power over the treasury and the army, so he needed time to focus on these as well.[10]

Of all these, most relevant at this point is that the king was meant to be a 'vijigishu' or would-be conqueror with, we are told, an ambition to own the whole world. Conquest and empire-building, or in other words the extension and exercise of a monarch's power within and beyond his realm, are quintessential within the state ideology outlined by this manual of politics. Naturally, such activity was bound up with every state's relations with all other states, contiguous and outlying. So, the would-be conqueror contemplating the expansion of his dominion had to overcome an impossible number of states in his quest for suzerainty, a fact of life discovered by megalomaniac conquerors such as Alexander and later the Roman Caesars. These other states are frequently denied an autonomous existence in contemporary narratives and primary sources by being defined wholly in relation to their territorial position *vis-à-vis* the would-be conqueror and his superordinate state.

Why were war and conquest so important? The bottom line appears to have been economic and strategic necessity: if you don't exercise power, you will find others exercising it over you. So the king was only properly a